nations who would make themselves our adversaries." He called on his unnamed adversary to "begin anew the quest for peace, before the dark powers of destruction unleashed by science engulf all humanity in planned or accidental self-destruction." Borrowing a phrase from the Harvard economist John Kenneth Galbraith, who advised him on the speech, Kennedy declared: "Let us never negotiate out of fear. But let us never fear to negotiate."

Kennedy was promising the rise of a new America in a new world. It would be based on liberty and brought into being through the dedication and sacrifice of American citizens. He promised Latin American countries —"sister republics," as he called them—to "convert our good words into good deeds" and form a "new alliance for progress" against poverty. "But this peaceful revolution of hope cannot become the prey of hostile powers," continued Kennedy. "Let all our neighbors know that we shall join with them to oppose aggression or subversion anywhere in the Americas. And let every other power know that this Hemisphere intends to remain the master of its own house."[5]

The Pax Romana inaugurated by Augustus at the turn of the common era was to be emulated by Kennedy's Pax Americana. But was that vision achievable? And could it be implemented by a young, inexperienced president? Robert Frost believed it could. The test of his vision and Kennedy's talents and determination still lay ahead. It came sooner than anyone expected and closer to American shores than could have been predicted. The name of the test was Cuba.

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IN THE TWENTIETH CENTURY, CUBA BECAME A SYMBOL OF America's failure to live up to the high standards of its own anti-imperial calling and the expectations raised by anticolonial revolutions around the world. A former Spanish colony, Cuba had played a catch-up game with the rest of the region when it came to liberation from colonial rule. Neighboring Haiti freed itself from French overlordship in 1804, and Mexico declared its independence from Spain in 1821, the year in which Simón Bolívar won